

1. Consent form: The consent forms are on the middle shelf on my desk (with a sticky note saying “consent forms (pilot)”). We need two copies of that for each participant: one form is for us to keep and the second one is for the participant to take home. **NOTE:** I have already printed out the consent form of the EEG study as well and it is on the lower shelf marked as (“consent (ERP)”). Whenever you take out a consent form please double check the first page, where it says “Title of the study”. For the behavioral study that we are currently running it should be “The time course of Attentional Capture and Hold”. If it’s another title, then it’s the wrong form!
2. Demographics and handedness questionnaires: The questionnaires are both attached to each other and are in the second shelf on my desk. Only one copy for each participant is needed. The participant’s code number (at the top of the demographics form) will be filled by us and it’s the participant’s initials following by the number of participation. For example, if I am running the 11th participant, and her name is Sepideh Hedayati (!), the code would be SH011.
3. While the participants go through the consent form I usually talk a little bit about the experiment. You can read from the text below:

“Thank you so much for being here. We really appreciate it. Our experiment is only behavioral, which means you will do a task with a computer. But since it’s an attention study we don’t want you to get distracted by your environment. So, we would want you to do it in this booth. It’s sound attenuated with a dim light so that the distractions are as low as they can get. When you are in the booth there is a camera that is on but it’s not recording you. We only have it there so that we make sure that you are looking at the monitor and not getting distracted. Also, if you needed anything during the task, you can wave at us through the camera so that we can come and get back to you.

There are no benefits for you in participating in this study. So, you won’t get faster, smarter, or stronger after doing the task. And it also won’t affect your grades here at UNC. You are just here to help us.

There are also no known risks in doing our task, but if you think something bad happened to you due to participating in this study, you have our contact information right on the consent form and the IRB who you can contact with and let us know about it.

The task takes almost 45 minutes to complete but it depends on how fast you respond to the targets that you see. But there will be resting times every 5 minutes or so to let you stretch, grab some water, or anything else you might need.

If you have any questions let us know and whenever you are ready we can start the experiment.”
4. We turn on the light, fan, the power cords and the monitor in the booth and turn on the other monitor by which we watch the participant as well.
5. The other computer outside the booth is automatically connected to the one in the booth but if it’s not showing anything, press the windows key and P and select Duplicate (it is written on the whiteboard in the back room too).
6. Ask the participant to leave anything that might distract them (like their phone or smart watch) outside the booth. Have the keyboard with the wooden board on the chair when participant is seated on the chair (they don’t need the mouse). Measure the distance of their eyes to the monitor (70 cm) and explain to them that we want to control this distance, so we are measuring it for everyone.
7. Run the experiment from the other computer outside the booth. The experiment is in the shared drive (Z) as follows:

This PC > joehop (<\\ad.unc.edu\cas\psychology\share>) (Z:) > LAB > Users > Sepideh > 19 in-person (Spring 2025)> 369 (the format is psychopy experiment)

8. There might be a “tip of the day” popping up, just close it. Click the run button (the green button at the top) and wait for it to bring the participant and session window. On the participant’s tab, write the participant’s ID number which we gave them earlier on the questionnaires (SH011 in our example) and click OK.
9. The task will run and as the instructions go you can read from them to the participant. You can say:
Thank you again for participating in this study. This experiment is pretty simple! You will see a fixation cross right in the middle of the screen. Please stay focused on the cross and do not look at anything else (ask the participant to press the spacebar whenever the instructions are over on each page to move forward). During this task you will see different images popping up on the right and left side of the cross. Please ignore them and just focus on the cross in the middle (press the spacebar). You will also see an asterisk popping up either on the right or left side of the cross. Your task is to press the right arrow key with your middle finger when the target is on the right and the left arrow key with your index finger when it’s on the left. You should only use your right hand (press the spacebar). Now we will have a practice phase so that you know how things work. You will get feedback on your accuracy and reaction time. Please try to answer as fast and accurate as you can. Whenever you’re ready press the spacebar to start the task.
10. The practice phase has 32 trials so it won’t take long. When they are done we open the door telling them they did great and that we are ready to start the actual experiment. During the actual task, you will not get any feedback. The task has 8 blocks and each of them can last for ~5 minutes depending on your reaction time. But after each block you will have a break and we will check up on you to see if you need anything or need to stand up, stretch, need water or anything else. When you are ready press the spacebar to start your first block.
11. We would check up on them on the monitor to make sure they are not sleepy, or if they are attentive enough or not. If they looked sleepy we can offer them coffee or water or anything they want during the breaks. You can also ask them if they need to stand up to make them sharper during the breaks. In my experiment wiggling is not a problem, so if they move their feet or anything, it’s ok (not ideal but ok, since it’s a very long task!).
12. When they are done with the last block they should press the spacebar one last time to exit the task. It takes a while for psychopy to get out of it (don’t worry if you see a black screen for a while). We will let the participant out and thank them again for their participation. And let them know that we will grant them the credit by the end of the day.
13. To check to see if the data was collected correctly and completely we will check the data folder on the same path:
This PC > joehop (<\\ad.unc.edu\cas\psychology\share>) (Z:) > LAB > Users > Sepideh > 19 in-person (Spring 2025) > data

There will be an excel file with the participant’s ID, date, and the time of the start of the experiment. When we open it look for the column with the following names (They are usually on the first few columns. Might be in the other columns too (especially the key_resp.rt)):

key_resp.key key_resp.corr key_resp.rt

key_resp.keys	key_resp.corr	key_resp.rt
right	1	0.9772
left	1	0.4525
right	1	0.3663
right	1	0.4723
right	1	0.4046
left	1	0.497
left	1	0.3803

These are the main data we would need for analyzing the results. Then scroll down until you reach the last block. There should be 1005 rows in the excel file of each participant.

14. When you checked the data you can close the file and PsychoPy. The PsychoPy might show an error while you want to close it (just click close anyway (or something like that!)).
15. Don't forget to turn the lights, monitor and fan off in the booth.
16. We put the consent form and questionnaires in the locked cabinet by the door (the lower one to the left), in the first folder when you open it (it's purple). The key to that is in the upper drawer of my desk (it's the silver one in the box where there are two keys). Please lock it again when you are done with putting the forms away.
17. That's it! Thank you so much for your help 😊